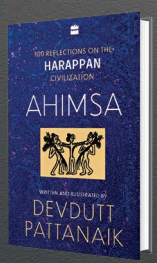
Q+A

PEACE ABOVE ALL

Devdutt Pattanaik offers an alternative view of the Harappan civilisation in his newest book, *Ahimsa: 100 Reflections on the Harappan Civilization*



AHIMSA
100 Reflections on the Harappan Civilization
By Devdutt Pattanaik
HARPERCOLLINS
₹**499; 272** pages

Q. You are known as a mythologist. With *Ahimsa*, have you forayed into history?
Mythology exists in history. Mythology changes over time. So one cannot ignore history. But my focus is on what Harappans believed, their subjective truth, so the realm of myth.

Q. What lessons from Harappa are relevant even today?
Trading is better than raiding. Fair trade prevents war. Fair trade demands contentment, which is psychological evolution, and not based on laws and policies.

Q. How much of the book–to use your own words–is 'known facts' and how much is 'informed speculation'?
The objects, the artifacts, the information on material culture, the movement of goods, the contemporary history, are all known facts. The interpretation of this web of information is speculation.

Q. Is your thesis–that Harappa was a non-violent civilisation–an unconventional one?
Many scholars have noticed that Harappan civilisation as compared to contemporary Mesopotamia and Egypt has far fewer indicators of violence. I link this to mercantile-monastic culture, like the much later connection of traders with Buddhism and Jainism. This reading is unconventional.

Q. What other creative projects are you pursuing at the moment?
Currently, I am fascinated by how material cultures of India reveal mythology quite differently from textual culture. And how stories in Prakrit are so different from stories told in Sanskrit.

–with Amit Dixit

Photograph by BANDEEP SINGH